

CHANGING SEA LEVELS

During the last cold period, so much water was locked up as ice that global sea levels fell by 330 ft (100 m). Shallow coastal seas dried out, including the Bering Strait between Siberia and Alaska. This allowed animals and people to migrate between Asia and America. By 11,000 years ago, rising temperatures had melted much of the ice and the seas filled up again. They also led to many species dying out.



ICE-SCoured LANDSCAPE

When the ice sheets and glaciers melted at the end of the last big freeze, they left their mark on the landscape. The glaciers had gouged deep U-shaped valleys (above). When these extended to the coast, they filled with water to become steep-walled fjords.

SNOWBALL EARTH

Throughout its history, Earth has experienced many ice ages. The most dramatic may have occurred about 650 million years ago. Clues in the rocks suggest that the entire planet was frozen, with land at the equator as cold as Antarctica is now. This “Snowball Earth” idea is disputed by many scientists, because it would have had a catastrophic effect on the evolution of life.

► ICY WORLD

If the Snowball Earth event really happened, our planet may have looked like ice-covered Europa, one of the moons of Jupiter.



▲ SABER TEETH

The fearsome saber-toothed cat became extinct when climate change caused the ice sheets to melt.

WATER

